In the long forgotten past, an unknown species ruled the universe. They were advanced beyond comprehension, but their reign was not destined to last forever. Now we call them the Eld. A seemingly innocuous discovery—that entropy in the universe was increasing at an inexplicably high rate—would spell their doom. In pursuing this incongruity, fringe scholars among their distinguished ranks developed the two river hypothesis. Imagine two rivers that run parallel to each other. The banks of one river are degrading by the volume of water flowing through it, and to prevent this degradation, an unknown actor diverts water from one river to another. Now the other river is degrading.

With the two river hypothesis, these scientists suggested that some actor in a parallel universe had found a way to dump entropy into their own universe. The death of their world was accelerating to prolong the order of another. Their fears were further confirmed by a shocking discovery: a method to send the entropy back. In proving this method, whomever had been dumping entropy in the first place became aware of them. The details are scant, but the retribution was immediate and permanent. The actor from the second river laid waste to the eld.

Realizing the terror of their position, the eld resolved to preserve their legacy through redundancy—a synthetic planet named Hiraeth. Originally built as a minor scientific outpost, Hiraeth is the stage of our lives now. The Eld embedded the neural state of one of their own, a female named Scio, to serve as the planet's overseer. For countless millennia Scio diligently shrouded Hiraeth in darkness. To the people from the second river it was a dusty rock, due the diligence of atmospheric fire, but not utter dismemberment. This obfuscation is what allowed Hiraeth to live on as a listening station into the future, seeded by a long extinct people.

When a new civilization finally arrived to Hiraeth, Scio unveiled a world of mysteries; inhospitable enough to avoid attention, intriguing enough to secure permanent residents. To mankind, Hiraeth was little more than a small stop between brighter stars. But just as the Eld were not meant to rule forever, so too did mankind fall into darkness, leaving those who made meager lives on Hiraeth isolated, stranded. With nowhere to go, Scio began her second directive: guide intelligent life to rediscover the threat of the second river, and seal it for good.

To this task, Scio bestowed a minor tribe of humans who called themselves Morivians—people of the path—five enlightened prophets. These prophets were imbued with the intuition to discover and navigate ruins left behind by the Eld, and in unlocking their secrets, they accumulated great power for the Morivians, who hailed them as Living Saints.

Scio's first attempt, however, was misguided. She underestimated the strength and cunning of mankind. It was not long before her five prophets uncovered Scio herself, and began to reckon with the plot they had been made pawns in. They learned how Scio had controlled the weather, plate tectonics. How she had guided the rise and fall of cities and tribes to cultivate humans capable of her task. How she had embedded in them a recognition for the Eld legacy. Discord was sown among the five prophets, who could not agree on what to do with this knowledge. Could they tell their people, or hide this secret? Could they displace Scio and assume absolute control of Hiraeth, or could any one person truly be trusted with that power? It is not known who delivered the first blow or the last, but when their argument led to violence, two prophets were slain.

The Living Saints could not form a plan, and in their weakened states, Scio banished them from the equator. She wracked the Morivian homeland with earthquakes, killed it with drought and famine. The Morivians could not stay, and the three Living Saints traveled with them. The original saints traveled North, while their empowered copies traveled to the South. As the Morivians spread, they unlocked more of the powers of the Eld, and dominated the hemispheres, while the equator, their homeland, was now foreign to them.

Some Morivians longed for the equator. They could not settle in the hemispheres like the others. They resented the Living Saints for leading them away from their ancestors. They felt betrayed by the temple, who, as they saw it, had placed themselves above the authority of ancient Morivian customs and beliefs. These Morivians removed themselves from the hemispheres, resolving to become custodians of the paths that lead to the equator, never themselves destined to return to a sun-baked home that rejects them. The Morivians call them the Va'a.

Before long, it became too dangerous to even cross the equator from one hemisphere to the other, and the two Morivian empires lost contact with one another. The North wonders what has become of the South. It has become a fixation of exotic imaginings. Men, unsatisfied with their lot in life, say, "In the South, I would be rich and happy." Young girls muse and daydream of their "husband from the South," who possesses every fantastical quality they could ever hope to assign to a partner. The Northern Morivians carry sorrow, as they quietly mourn the dual loss of a mother-father in the equator, and a brother-sister in the south. There is no family for the Morivians.

The Eld

- Ancient, advanced, powerful, extinct.
- Hiraeth (synthetic planet), Scio (the last Eld, a computer), ruined technology.

The Second River

- Entropy-dumping.
- Cannot ascribe any feeling to them. They view our universe as a waste dump. They easily erased the most powerful civilization to ever exist for the crime of splashing in the pool.
- Someone who knows how to push entropy around like they can is viewed as an existential threat. They are watching, and they will lay waste to the universe if they even detect a hint that someone might be on the path to freely moving entropy.

Scio

- The last Eld, consciousness reduced to a computer network.
- Oversees all operations on Hiraeth, weather, tectonics, magnetism, etc.
- First directive: preserve intelligent life at all costs.
    - This means destroying life if it becomes advanced enough to be noticed by the Second River.
- Second directive: guide intelligent life to finishing the work left behind by the Eld.
    - Shut out the Second River forever.
- Affected by a "data blinder." Scio cannot identify the names and qualities of individuals in the populations she manages. Eld feared she would become too sentimental to carry out her first directive efficiently.

The Living Saints

- Created via hyper-prion-like proteins that infect the brain and simulate neural attractor states that impart inexplicable intuition.
- Sallus Ven (male), Vespera (female), Trinivar (male), Meridian (male, deceased), Elicar (male, deceased).
- Degenerate and die quickly because of their prion disease.
- Morivians don't understand the Saints are sick, truly just interpret their intuition as divine revelation and power.
- Saints are kept "living" by infecting younger vessels when the old saint dies.

The Va'a

- Keepers of the old ways from the equator, remember a time before the saints and the complicated, busy, tech-focused world of the Northern Empire.
- Viewed as heretics by the Morivian Temple (who venerate the Saints).

- Common Morivian people view them as orthodox, recognize commonality, but still see themselves as coming from different worlds.

The Northern Empire